GS FOUNDATION
BATCH FOR CSE 2024

Ancient, Medieval & Culture - 9
(Vijayanagar + Bahmani)

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VIJAYANAGAR EMPIRE (1336-1565)

SANGAM DYNASTY (1336-1485)

- **Harihara and Bukka were feudatories of the Hoysalas at Kampili (Karnataka).**
    - In 1326, the armies of Muhammad bin Tughlaq overran the Deccan.
    - Harihara and Bukka were defeated, arrested and brought to delhi, where they were converted to Islam.
    - They were restored to Kampili to rule in the name of Delhi's Sultan.

- According to legend, they were re-converted by their guru, **Vidyaranya**, and in 1336, they declared independence from the Sultanate.
    - They built a **new capital at Vijayanagar** (present day Hampi) on the banks of **Tunghbadhra**.
    - They ruled jointly and assumed titles such as 'Hindu Suratana'.

The most famous Sangam kings were-

- **Devaraya I**

    - During his reign, **NICCOLO CONTI (Italian traveller)** visited Vijayanagara.
        - He has given a detailed account of the city of Vijayanagar, which according to him, was **"as large and as beautiful as Rome".**
        - He has also commented on the prevalence of **Sati**.

- **Devaraya II**

    - During his reign, the **Persian traveller ABDUR RAZZAQ** visited India. He first visited the Zamorin of Calicut and then went to the Vijaygnara empire.

        - He was a historian and scholar from Herat, sent to Vijayanagar as an **ambassador** of the ruler of **Khurasan, Shah Rukh Mirza**, to the court of Deva Raya II.

        - He has described the time period of Deva Raya II in his travelogue, **'Matla-us-Sadain wa Majma-ul-Bahrain'.**

        - He specially describes the **wealth and splendour** of the capital. He vouches that Vijayanagar's market was ten times the size of Herat's market.
            - He says Vijayanagar was the **largest and the most well provisioned city** in the world.
            - According to him, **traders of precious metals and jewels** flocked its streets and bazaars, and the market sold every commodity imaginable.
            - He mentions that the Vijayanagara **treasury was filled with molten gold nuggets.**

- According to him, Vijayanagara had **seven fortification walls** within which there were provisions of all year water supply and agriculture fields.
- He mentions that the **Sati** system prevailed in Vijayanagara.
- According to him, state derived taxation income from **prostitution and brothels.**
- He pegs the strength of Vijayanagara **army** at 11 lakh and counts the number of **ports** at 300.

SULUVA DYNASTY (1485-1506)

Founder - **Suluva Narsimha**

TULUVA DYNASTY (1506-1565)

Founder - **Vir Narsimha**

Krishna Deva Raya (1509-1529)

- He is the most famous king of Vijayanagar. He was also mentioned by Babur in **'Tuzuk-i-Baburi'**. Babur has referred to him as the most capable ruler in India.
- He was a **great warrior** who made territorial gains at the cost of Bijapur and the Gajpatis of Odisha.
- He was also a **great patron of the arts**.
  - He himself was an accomplished write, and wrote:
    - **'Amukta Malyada'** - a Telugu work on statecraft.
    - **'Jambavati Kalyanam'** - a Sanskrit play.
  - His court was adorned with 8 accomplished scholars and poets called the **Ashtadiggajas**, the most famous being Tenali Raman.
  - During his period, Telugu literature emerged out of the shadow of Sanskrit literature.
  - He also patronised Tamil and Kannada literature.
- During his reign, **2 Portuguese travellers** visited the empire-
  - **DURATE BARBOSA** -
    - He describes the **ship building and sati** system.
    - He mentions that diamond and precious stones were imported from Pegu and silk was imported from China, whereas, black pepper came from Malabar coast.

- **DOMINGO PAES**
  - He was received by Krishnadeva Raya at his court.
  - He has described the beauty of Vijayanagar and the king's personal attributes.
  - According to him, Krishna deva raya was a warrior king, whose body was covered in battlescars.

- During Krishnadeva Raya's reign the Vijaygnara empire **gained strategic edge over the Adil Shahis of Bijapur.**
  - He **helped the Portuguese in capturing Goa**, and secured a **monopoly on war horses**.

Achyuta Raya

During his reign, the Portuguese horse trader, **FERNANDO NUNIZ**, visited the empire.

- He has mainly described the social and cultural aspects of Vijayanagara in his travelogue.
  - He says that there were **women scribes, wrestlers, astronomers, musicians and fortune tellers** in Vijayanagara.
  - He also mentions the **social evils like dowry, Sati and child marriage** which prevailed in the Vijayanagara society.
  - He praises the **Brahmins** of Vijayanagara as **honest** people who were **good scribes** also.
  - According to Nuniz, the **rulers of Quilon, Sri Lanka, Pulicat, Pegu, Tennasserim and Malaya paid tribute** to the Vijayanagara King.
  - He also describes the **Nayankara system** and says that the **rate of land revenue was 1/10th.**

Administration

Kingship

- The Vijayanagara empire was ruled by the **absolute monarch**, who assumed high sounding titles such as 'Maharajadhiraja', 'Andrabhoja', 'Hindu Suratana', etc.
- The element of **divine origin** of kingship was also a peasant.
  - The kings ruled in the name of Lord Virupaksha.
- Despite being an absolute monarchy, there were some **customary checks** on the kings which made their rule **benevolent** in nature.
- The empire had a **fixed rule of succession**.

- The king would nominate his heir and successor during his own lifetime. It was usually his brother or eldest son.
- The empire would be ruled by the **King and the Yuvraj simultaneously**, as such, the transition of power was usually smooth and peaceful.
- Thus, unlike north India, it was able to escape the disastrous effects of frequent wars of succession.

- However, **powerful feudal elements** were also present, complicating both the internal and external politics of the state.

Central Administration

- The central government was organised in the form of a **Mantri Parishad** (cabinet). The King was the chief executive and was advised by his top mantris (ministers).

- The mantri parishad was assisted by **Sachivalaya** (Secretariat).
  - It looked after the day to day administration and implementation of policy directives from the king and mantri parishad.
  - It consisted of representatives from the
    - central government,
    - provincial governments and
    - feudal lords, called Amarnyakas.

Taxation

- **Land revenue** was the most important source of state income. It was collected at the variable rate, from **1/6th to 1/4th**, of the produce, based on the quality of land.

- There were **no exemptions or exceptions** in the collection.
  - It was collected even from priests and temples, albeit at the concessional rate.
    - **'Brahmadeya'** land (granted to priests) - 1/20th of the produce.
    - **'Devadana'** land (granted to temples) - 1/30th of produce.

- Various economic activities such as **trade, commerce, mining, forestry, gambling and even marriages** were also taxed.
  - However, **widow remarriages were exempted** from marriage tax.

- **Prostitution** was legal and the state collected **taxes from brothels**.

Provincial Administration

The empire was divided into Several **'Rajyas/ Mandalams'** (provinces), headed by a Rajayapala, who usually belonged to the royal family. Rajyapals enjoyed the following rights:

- Could collect taxes
- Could autonomously levy or abolish taxes
- Could issue their own currency in their own name.
- Could maintain their own armies

Nayankara System

It was a system of **military feudalism.**

- The **Nayakas/Amarnayakas (top military officials)** were paid in the form of Land grants known as **'Amarams'**.
- Gradually these grants became hereditary and Amarnayakas became participants in sharing state power.
- They enjoyed the following powers:
  - Could maintain their own armies.
  - Could collect taxes.
  - However, they had no rights to abolish/ levy taxes or to issue their own currency.
- Thus the Vijayanagar administration was a synthesis of centralised monarchy and feudalism.

Ayagar System

It was a system of **local government in villages**.

- Each village had **12 officials nominated by the state**, called **Ayagars.**
- They were chosen primarily from among **local Brahmins** and were paid in the form of **land grants**.
- Each Ayagar was responsible for a **different function** such as irrigation, maintenance of public spaces, organising fairs and festivals, setting prices of local goods, etc.
- The position of Ayagars was **hereditary and saleable** i.e. they could sell it to someone else.
- This system closely resembled Chola village administration except that the element of election, which was missing.

Society

The society was caste based and hierarchical, however, unlike north India, there was not a four-fold Varna division, rather the society had Brahmins and Non-Brahmins.

- **Brahmins** held the supreme position and enjoyed both political power and social prestige.
  - The kings, top officials, ministers, army commanders, etc. were Brahmin.
  - Brahmin priests received lightly taxed land grants.

- Educational institutions were completely under their control
- Religious life was characterised by regimented ritualism due to which their importance increased.

- The Non-Brahmins were divided into the **Valangai (right handed) and Idangai (left handed) castes.**
  - The Valangai group consisted of castes with an agricultural basis, whereas,
  - The Idangai group consisted of castes which were involved in manufacturing, craft and trading etc.

- The **society was not divided along blood relations but on the basis of geography**.
  - So, it was common that blood relatives living in separate geographical areas establish marital relations.

- Due to Brahmanical orthodoxy prevalent in the Vijayanagara society, the **condition of women** in the Vijayanagara society was no better than north India.

  - **Child Marriage and Polygamy** were common.

  - **Widow remarriages** were considered **taboo**.
    - However, the **rulers encouraged it** through tax exemptions.

  - **Tippadiyal (Sati)** was also popular.
    - At the same time, we also find evidence of male Royal bodyguards jumping onto the funeral pyres of deceased kings.

  - In temples, **Devadasis** were heavily exploited but the condition of **Ganikas** was far better.

- Although the Varnashrama Dharma system was rigidly observed, the **Vijayanagara kings were remarkably liberal and practical in their outlook.**

  - They readily **patronised** skilled artisans, workmen, scholars and **promoted** able administrators and military commanders **from all backgrounds, including Muslims.**

  - They **welcomed Christian missionaries** from Portugal.

  - They even **joined hands with the Golconda Sultanate against the Gajpati rulers.**

BAHMANI SULTANATE (1347-1687)

Unified Bahmani (1347-1482)

In 1347, **Alauddin Hassan/ Hassan Gangu/ Bahman Shah** established a new kingdom with its capital at **Gulbarga** (Karnataka) by rebelling against the Delhi Sultanate and breaking away from it.

Firoz Shah Bahmani

- He was a **learned ruler** with vast knowledge of history, logic, religion, grammar, astronomy, mathematics and medicine.
    - He was conversant in several languages such as Arabic, Persian, Turkish, Urdu, Kannada and Telugu.

- He was **tolerant** of other religions and had personally read both the Old and New Testament.
    - It was during his reign that **Gesu Daraz**, the famous Chishti Sufi saint established his Khanqah at Gulbarga.

- The **decline of the Delhi Sultanate** meant that many **learned men migrated** from Delhi to the Gulbarga.

- Firoz also **invited scholars and nobles from Iraq and Iran**.
    - Many of these West Asian migrants were Shiite. Under their influence, **Persian culture and Shiite doctrine** grew within the Bahmani Sultanate.

- He also **inducted a large number of Hindus in administration**, which possibly acted as a balance against the influx of foreigners called Afaqis or Gharibs.

- He built an **observatory at Daulatabad**.

- Having **initially defeated Devaraya I**, he was **later** dealt a crushing defeat by a Warangal-Vijayanagar alliance led by Devaraya I and was **forced to abdicate** in favour of his brother Ahmad Shah 'Wali'.

Ahmed Shah Wali

- He is remembered more for his contribution as **sufi saint** than as a ruler. He was a close associate of Gesu Daraz and his death anniversary is jointly celebrated by both Hindus and Muslims.

- He **conquered Warangal**, thus breaking the Vijayanagar-Warangal alliance. Following this, he **shifted the capital to Bidar** to better control the newly conquered territory.

- As a result, **Vijayanagar was considerably weakened**. The period after Devaraya II was a period of chaos and the frontiers of Vijayanagar shrank on all sides.

Mahmud Gawan

He was the **Wakil-us Sultanat (Prime Minister)** of the Bahmani Sultanate during the reign of **Muhammad Shah III**.

- He carried out the administrative reorganisation of the Sultanate by dividing it into 8 provinces '**Taraf/Atrafs'.**
- He also **strengthened the military by including local Marathas** in the army.
    - He introduced the practice of making **land grants** to top commanders, thus winning Maratha loyalty.
- He introduced the system of **survey and measurement** for land revenue.
- He **patronised arts and literature.**
    - He constructed the famous **madrasa at Bidar** in the traditional Persian style called **'REGISTAN'**.

During his tenure as Wakil, the factional struggle between the **Deccanis and Aqafis/ Gharibs** peaked. As a result Muhammad Gawan was executed, shortly after which the kingdom disintegrated.

Afanasy Nikitin

- He was possibly the first **Russian** traveller to come to India.
    - He has described both Vijayanagar and Bahamani kingdom in the 15th century.

- Nikitin calls **Mahmud Gawan**, 'Tuzzar', as Mahmud Gawan held the title of **'Malik-i-Tuzzar'.**

- According to him, the **land was very populous** and the **common people were very poor**. But the **nobles lived in great luxury**.
    - Nikitin was amazed to see the **king and the nobles ride on men**. Perhaps he refers to palanquins carried by four to twenty men on special occasions.

- It was his observation that, in India, **everyone goes naked**. All were **barefoot**, **walked fast** and were **strong**.
    - The intensity of heat possibly made people use scanty clothes. Perhaps this practice made Nikitin think that they went 'naked'.

Successor States (1482-1687)

- **Ahmednagar** - it was ruled by the **Nizam Shahi** dynasty.
    - In **1601** it was forced to accept the Mughal suzerainty by Akbar.
    - It was finally annexed by Shah Jahan in **1636**.
- **Bidar** - it was ruled by the **Barid Shahi** Dynasty and was absorbed by the Ahmednagar Sultanate.
- **Berar** - it was ruled by the **Imad Shahi** dynasty, and was also absorbed by the Ahamednagar.
- **Bijapur** - it was ruled by the **Adil Shahi** dynasty.
    - It was forced to accept the Mughal suzerainty by the Shah Jahan in **1636** and later annexed by Aurangzeb in **1686**.
- **Golkonda** - it was ruled by the **Qutub Shahi** dynasty and suffered the same fate as Bijapur.
    - Shah Jahan established Mughal overlordship over it in **1636** and Aurangzeb annexed it in **1687**.

Important personalities

- **Ibrahim Adil Shah -** He built the Gol Gumbaz at Bijapur, the largest dome in Asia.
    - He was also known as **Jagatguru** due to his religious tolerance, love for knowledge and music.

- **Malik Ambar -** originally a **slave from Ethiopia** named Chapu.
    - He was educated and trained in Baghdad, converted to Islam and renamed.
    - He was **sold into the service of Malik Dabir (Royal Scribe) of Ahmednagar** under whom he gained administrative and military experience.
    - After the death of his master, he was freed and became a **military leader**, raising his own force.
    - Mughal aggression towards the Deccan allowed him to quickly rise in power.
    - He became the **Prime Minister** and had his daughter married to the Sultan of Ahmednagar, becoming the **regent** and **de facto ruler of Ahmednagar**.
    - He joined hands with the Marathas to successfully resist Mughal encroachment.

Bahmani - Vijayanagar Struggle

The 14th century saw the emergence of two powerful Deccani kingdoms.

- **Bahamani Sultanate** covered the linguistic region of **Telugu, Kannada and Marathi**. It was situated to the north of the Vijaynagar Empire.
- The **Vijaynagar Empire** covered the linguistic region of **Telugu, Tamil, Kannada**.
    - Their proximity led to a number of disputes between the two kingdoms and their history in rife with incessant warfare. For almost 200 years, they fought for the control of,
        - The **Konkan Coast**, including important ports such as Goa and Dabhol

        - **Raichur Doab** (between the Krishna and the Tunghbadhra)
        - **Krishna-Godavari Delta**
- During this period, their fortunes shifted constantly.
- Finally in 1565, the combined armies of 4 successor states (Ahmednagar, Bijapur, Golconda and Bidar) defeated the Vijayanagar Empire, being led by Rama Raya, in the decisive Battle of **Talikota/ Bannihatti/ Rakshasa Tagadi.**
- The Vijaynagar empire collapsed after this.
    - However, some of its Amara Nayakas continued to rule independently.

Level Up IAS